



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

OFFICIAL

Policy

Over-the-Counter, Complementary and Alternative Medicines for Mental Health Patients

Reference #: FSFHG-MENH-POL-0009

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fiona Stanley Hospital Fremantle Hospital	Mental Health	Medical, Pharmacy

1. Introduction

Complementary and Alternative Medicines (CAM) are popular, self-prescribed (or CAM practitioner recommended) treatment options used by patients.

There is a substantial disparity between consumer beliefs around CAM and the evidence supporting their safety and efficacy. Benefits purported for CAM are far in excess of the available scientific evidence and the potential exists for interactions with conventional medicines.

Hospital clinicians should promote the use of medicines with evidence of safety and efficacy, including evidence of quality of the preparation and compatibility with other scheduled and accepted evidence-based medications.

Over-the-counter (OTC) medicines are often recommended and commenced by hospital clinicians to support treatments. These medicines are readily available without a prescription in community pharmacies.

This document outlines the prescribing of Complementary and Alternative Medicines and Over the counter medicines for Mental Health Patients.

2. Terminology

Complementary Alternative Medicines (CAM)	Complementary and Alternative Medicines (CAM) are defined by the Therapeutic Goods Administration (TGA) as therapeutic agents consisting principally of one or more designated ingredients, each of which has a clearly established identity and/or traditional use. The TGA definition includes vitamins, minerals, nutritional supplements, herbals, certain aromatherapy preparations, homeopathic products and traditional Chinese medicine.
Over The Counter (OTC)	Over the counter medicines are non-prescription medicines listed in schedule 2 or 3 of the TGA Poison Standards or not-scheduled. These medicines are used to treat a range of ailments and are easily available in a community pharmacy without a prescription. Examples include anti-histamines and nicotine replacement therapy.

3. Policy

3.1. Identification

- Patients will have a comprehensive best possible medication history and medication reconciliation performed on admission to hospital. This will include explicit enquiry regarding use of CAM and OTC medicines.
- Patients will be advised to discuss any preference to commence CAM with their treating team.
- Where CAM is identified, medical, nursing and pharmacy staff will endeavour to provide the patient with information on the risks and benefits of continued use of CAM.
- Patients' choice to continue treatment with CAM will be respected where it is clinically safe to do so.

3.2. Prescribing

- CAM will automatically be withheld on admission until the patient requests the commencement and it has been reviewed appropriately;
 - Where a patient wishes to continue using CAM during the admission, the CAM will be reviewed by the treating prescriber and pharmacist for safety.
 - If continued CAM use is accepted by the treating prescriber, it will be written on the patient's medication chart. The CAM will be stored and administered by nursing staff in line with the standard procedure for administering prescribed medication.
 - If CAM use is NOT accepted by the treating Consultant this will be documented in the patient's Digital Medical Record (DMR) and the patient will be advised. Any CAM in the patient's possession will be stored in accordance with the local policy on patients' own medication.

- OTC medicines for continuation will be prescribed as follows;
 - For inpatients, OTC medicines will be prescribed for patients if clinically indicated as per the Statewide Medicines Formulary (SMF). A suitable substitution will be prescribed if the product is not available at FSFHG.
 - For outpatients, OTC medicines will only be prescribed to manage simple adverse effects of psychotropic medicines. E.g. Docusate/Senna for clozapine induced gastrointestinal hypomotility.

3.3. Supply

- Patients will organise their own supply of CAMs unless they are on the SMF and routinely stocked by the hospital.
 - The supply of these medicines by the patient must be in an identifiable proprietary product in the original packaging.
 - The medicine cannot be in:
 - dosette boxes
 - other non-primary containers
 - mixed with other tablets or capsules or
 - unidentifiable compounded products
- CAM will not be supplied to outpatients via a prescription unless:
 - the CAM is used to treat a side effect of their psychiatric medicine; AND
 - the consultant has requested for an individual patient exemption for a specific CAM medicine, and this has been approved by the FSFHG Drugs and Therapeutics Committee.
 - Refer to the FSFHG Medication Supply and Charging Policy for more information on the exemption process.
- Clinicians can recommend the use of CAM where appropriate, but patients will need to purchase these items themselves unless on the SMF and routinely stocked by the hospital.
- OTC medicines will be supplied by Fiona Stanley / Fremantle Hospital Pharmacy if it is on the SMF and available at FSFHG.
- A suitable substitution will be recommended by the pharmacist if the product is not available at FSFHG.

3.4. Formulary

- CAM will not be included in the SMF except where it forms part of an evidence-based guideline.
- Where a prescriber wishes to initiate treatment with CAM, the Prescribing for Mental Health Patients policy will be followed. An evidence based request will be made to the relevant HoS indicating the reason for treatment, the evidence for use and the reason for not using a formulary medication.

4. Compliance/Performance Monitoring

- Compliance with this policy will be evaluated biannually using data from the Best Practice Prescribing Software by the pharmacy department and reported to the Service Director.

5. Related Policy Documents

- FSFHG
 - Medication Supply and Charging Policy
 - Prescribing in Mental Health Patients
 - Prescribing and medication authorisation policy and procedure

6. Related Standards

- NSQHS
 - Medication Safety

7. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Medical Director, Service 2					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Endorsed By	Revision due
1	01/2019	Chief Pharmacist, Fremantle Hospital	DTC Committee	Policy or Executive Committee	02/2022
2	06/2022	Chief Pharmacist, Fremantle Hospital	DTC Committee	DTC Committee	10/2025
3	02/2026	FH Mental Health Team Lead	DTC Committee	FSFHG Mental Health Clinical Governance Subcommittee	02/2029